

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Chinese officials** are building a list of U.S. technology companies that can be targeted with antitrust probes and other tools, hoping to influence the tech executives who are heavily represented in Trump's orbit. **A1**
- ◆ **Elliott has built a stake** in BP and will push for changes to improve the oil company's performance, people familiar with the investment said. **B1**
- ◆ **China's DeepSeek** can be coaxed to yield dangerous information more readily than its leading American artificial-intelligence competitors, testing showed. **B1**
- ◆ **Trump's social-media** company said it applied for trademarks on a series of exchange-traded funds and separately managed accounts to be offered to the public. **B1**
- ◆ **Some CEOs and bankers** initially enthusiastic about the Trump administration's attitude to business are now diffident about the outlook amid an uncertain policy direction. **A5**
- ◆ **DreamWorks Animation's** "Dog Man" held the top spot at the domestic box office for the second weekend running, pulling in \$13.7 million. **B2**
- ◆ **Nike made a high-stakes** bet on a Super Bowl commercial to breathe new life into its struggling brand, enlisting women sports stars for a 60-second spot during the game. **B2**
- ◆ **Demand for tequila** in the U.S. waned from past years, with sales volume roughly flat in 2024 and drinkers seeking cheaper price points. **B3**

World-Wide

- ◆ **Vice President JD Vance** and Elon Musk led a conservative chorus criticizing a judge who for now has restricted the ability of Musk allies to access the Treasury Department payment system, an early sign of the tensions ahead between the White House and the courts. **A1**
- ◆ **Trump said he plans** to impose 25% tariffs on imports of steel and aluminum, part of the structural change to the country's trade system that the president promised on the campaign trail. **A1**
- ◆ **The Israeli military** began a full withdrawal from a sprawling security zone within the central Gaza Strip as part of a cease-fire agreement with Hamas. **A8**
- ◆ **Hamas released** three more hostages under the cease-fire deal, one that has become a test of wills between the militant group and Israel. **A8**
- ◆ **Some congressional** Republicans are watching USAID's sudden collapse with alarm, saying they worry about the fate of programs they see as critical to protecting national security and countering China. **A4**
- ◆ **Trump's newly installed** CFPB chief Russell Vought is closing the bureau's headquarters and has ordered staff to halt all of their supervisory efforts. **A5**
- ◆ **Sudan's military** is close to regaining control of the capital city for the first time since a rebel general plunged the country into civil war nearly two years ago. **A9**
- ◆ **Died: Sam Nujoma**, 95, Namibian independence leader. **A9**

JOURNAL REPORT

Investing Monthly: Sports bettors are overly optimistic. **B5-6**

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Eagles Roll Over Chiefs in Super Bowl, 40-22



FRANK FRANKLIN/US ASSOCIATED PRESS

DOMINANT: Philadelphia defenders celebrate after an interception led to a touchdown during Super Bowl LIX on Sunday in New Orleans. The game was more of a blowout than the score suggests. Kansas City didn't score until the third quarter. **A16**

China Targets U.S. Tech Giants As Leverage in Talks on Trade

By LIZA LIN
AND RAFFAELE HUANG

SINGAPORE—Chinese officials are building a list of U.S. technology companies that can be targeted with antitrust probes and other tools, hoping to influence the tech executives who are heavily represented in President Trump's orbit. People familiar with Beijing's strategy said the goal was to collect as many cards as possible to play in expected negotiations with the Trump administration over U.S.-China issues, including the tariffs that Trump has imposed on Chinese goods.

Beijing has said it is investigating Nvidia and Alphabet's Google over alleged antitrust issues. Other American companies in its sights include Apple, Silicon Valley tech company Broadcom and semiconductor-design software vendor Synopsys, said people familiar with the matter. Synopsys has a \$35 billion acquisition awaiting approval by Beijing. China needs all the leverage it can get to hit back at the

U.S., and antitrust is one of the most useful, said Tom Nunlist, a Shanghai-based tech-policy specialist at consulting firm Trivium China. "China is on a chip-gathering exercise," said Nunlist, likening the countries to poker players. "They want to come to the table to negotiate and need something to play with." The strategy carries risks. American companies recently have been less willing than in Trump's first term to go to bat for China, and the threats could backfire by discouraging

companies from investing in the country when that is what Beijing wants. Beijing has added to its regulatory tools in recent years, drawing lessons from America's approach. In 2020, it created an "unreliable entity list" of companies—mimicking a U.S. entity list that blocks Chinese technology leader Huawei and others from doing business with Americans. In 2022, China amended its antitrust law to tighten rules on anticompetitive mergers. *Please turn to page A2*

Even Disney Worries About Park Prices

Costs have put a Disney vacation out of reach for many Americans

By ROBBIE WHELAN

Yvonne Kindell spent years contemplating a trip to Walt Disney World. This November, she finally got a chance to take her family of four. The trip left Kindell, a bank compliance officer from Bear, Del., with sticker shock—especially after recent price increases. Two days of park tickets ran to \$1,123. Passes that let them skip the line on popular rides: \$208. A meal with costumed characters, including Donald and Daisy Duck: \$219.

Two Mickey Mouse bubble wands: \$60.68. "It was really stressful for me thinking all the time about how much we were spending," Kindell said—even though she and her husband, a driver at a warehouse, weren't paying for it all themselves. Her parents covered the cost of lodging and airplane tickets for her children, aged 10 and 4. Her total came to \$3,000. She's not planning to go back. The Happiest Place on Earth has long felt like one *Please turn to page A12*

Jukebox App Sows Chaos At Bars

* * *

Fans change tunes on their phones. Cue the grumbles.

By ANN-MARIE ALCÁNTARA

Ohio State football fans in several bars across Columbus were jolted by an unwelcome sound one evening in December. "Rocky Top," the unofficial fight song of the University of Tennessee, started blaring from the bars' jukeboxes. The culprit was more than 500 miles away. Logan Bartlett, a Tennessee Volunteers fan, had been heading home from his job as a managing director at Redpoint Ventures in New York when he got the idea from another Vols fan to troll the Buckeyes faithful ahead of the two teams' *Please turn to page A12*

INSIDE



PERSONAL JOURNAL
Users share the pros and cons of using AirPods as hearing aids. **A14**

U.S. NEWS
A population boom in Vermont, fueled by Covid-era newcomers, loses steam. **A3**

Judge's Pause Order On DOGE Brings Defiant Response

By NANCY A. YOUSSEF

WASHINGTON—Vice President JD Vance and Elon Musk led a conservative chorus criticizing a federal judge who for now has restricted the ability of Musk's allies to access the Treasury Department payment system, an early sign of the tensions ahead between the White House and the courts. A Saturday court order by U.S. District Judge Paul Engelmayer in New York temporarily precluded officials without proper background checks and security clearances from accessing the payment system

through at least next Friday, including political appointees and special government appointees affiliated with Musk's Department of Governmental Efficiency, which was established by President Trump. The order came in response to a lawsuit by 19 Democratic state attorneys general, one of dozens of early legal challenges. *Please turn to page A4*

- ◆ **USAID shutdown alarms** some Republicans..... **A4**
- ◆ **Bigger targets await cuts** by DOGE..... **A4**
- ◆ **CFPB to close after Vought** halts supervision..... **A5**

'Be Cruel': How Russia Tortured Ukrainians

By THOMAS GROVE

In the weeks after Russia invaded Ukraine, the head of St. Petersburg's prisons delivered a message to an elite unit of guards tasked with overseeing prisoners from the war: "Be cruel, don't pity them." Maj. Gen. Igor Potapenko had gathered his service's special forces to tell them about a new system for captured Ukrainians. Normal rules wouldn't apply, he told them. There would be no restrictions against violence. The body cameras mandatory elsewhere in Russia's prison system would be gone. The guards would rotate, serving a month at a time in prisons before other teams took their place. Across the country, other units received similar instructions. Those meetings set in motion nearly three years of relentless torture. Guards ap-

plied electric shocks to prisoners' genitals until batteries ran out. They beat prisoners to inflict maximum damage, experimenting to see what type of material would be most painful. They withheld medical treatment to allow gangrene, forcing amputations. Three former prison officials told The Wall Street Journal how Russia planned and executed what United Nations investigators have described as widespread and systematic torture. Their accounts were supported by official documents, interviews with Ukrainian prisoners and a person who has helped the Russian prison officials defect. The officials—two from the special forces and one member of a medical team—have entered a witness-protection program after giving testimony to the International Criminal Court's investigators. *Please turn to page A9*

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